

Second Opinion

Allied Health Practice Guideline #20

Scope

Site	Service/Department/Unit	Disciplines
SCGOPHCG	Allied Health	Dietetics, Occupational Therapy, Physiotherapy, Podiatry, Psychology, Social Work and Speech Pathology

Introduction

In accordance with the Australian Charter of Healthcare Rights, all patients in Western Australian public hospitals have a fundamental right to seek a second opinion regarding their treatment.

SCGOPHCG Allied Health staff will assist patients to obtain a second opinion if requested.

Risk Statement

Non-compliance with this guideline:

Breach legislative requirements	☒	Impact on Patient Quality of Care	☒
Breach National/State/Hospital Policy	☒	Impact on Patient Safety	☒
Breach professional standards	☒	Misconduct	☐
Breach SCGOPHCG Mission & Values	☒	Staff Safety	☐
Other:	☐		

Guideline Details

SCGOPHCG inpatients and outpatients may request a second opinion if they are not satisfied with their recommended management plan. The patient may request this second opinion verbally or in writing to the treating Allied Health professional or their respective Head of Department.

The second opinion will be arranged by the treating clinician or the Head of Department using another suitably qualified/credentialed Allied Health professional from within SCGOPHCG.

If the second opinion does not recommend a change to the management plan, intervention may continue with the original treating Allied Health professional.

If the second opinion indicates that the management plan should be modified or discontinued, the original treating Allied Health professional or senior clinician will consider the alternate recommendations but is not obliged to act on these recommendations. The original Allied Health professional may continue treating.

If the patient remains dissatisfied, the respective senior clinician or Head of Department will review and give direction to treatment.

Patients may request additional opinions however there is no requirement to provide third or fourth opinions except where there has been a significant time lapse between the first and second opinions and /or significant change in circumstances/medical condition and /or significantly different opinion regarding treatment.

SCGOPHCG Allied Health staff may request a second opinion and/or specialist advice for inpatient and outpatients from:

- SCGOPHCG Allied Health profession specific supervisors or relevant clinical seniors
- SCGOPHCG Medical staff
- SCGOPHCG Nurse Practitioners/CNC/CNS

SCGOPHCG Allied Health staff may seek verbal advice from specialist Allied Health staff from other Health Service Providers when that expertise is not available at SCGOPHCG due to staff leave or site clinical specialisations. This verbal advice will be acknowledged in the medical record entry of the treating SCGOPHCG Allied Health professional.

External Allied Health practitioners are not permitted to provide a second opinion directly to SCGOPHCG inpatients.

Compliance, monitoring and evaluation

Staff are responsible for ensuring they document in the medical record when a patient requests a second opinion. The outcome of the second opinion, the name and profession of the clinician providing the opinion, and what actions were consequently undertaken, should be recorded in the medical record. Compliance with this guideline will be monitored via audits of clinical documentation.

Related Documents

[Australian Charter of Healthcare Rights \(second edition\)](#)

Authorisation

Policy Sponsor	Director Allied Health				
Policy Contact	Director Allied Health				
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Standards Applicable	Insert relevant NSQHS Standards (Version 2): 				